



Plants for banks and slopes

Slopes and banks add interest to designs, the layers of planting producing a three-dimensional effect. For best results, use tough, drought-tolerant plants.

Slopes offer a palette for color and texture, creating stunning features, but drought and erosion can present problems on steep hills. Plants with spreading root systems, such as cranesbills, junipers, heathers and heaths, bind the soil and protect it from erosion, while a leafy canopy minimizes rain damage. Choose drought-tolerant plants that can cope with dry soil; if the slope is exposed also consider their wind resistance. Most of these plants will cope with blustery conditions, but a few, including roses and hemlock, do best on slopes sheltered from prevailing winds.



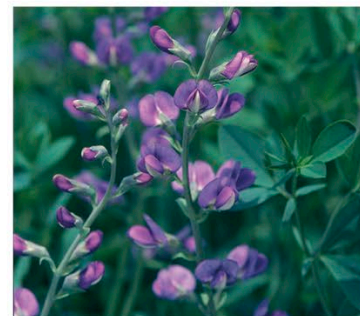
SHRUB SMALL

Abies balsamea **Hudsonia Group**

BALSAM FIR A slow-growing evergreen conifer, it can cope with the well-drained conditions on a slope. It forms a spreading mound of needlelike, dark gray-green leaves. Plant it in neutral to acidic soil.

↑↔3ft (1m)

☹ ☀️ pH Z3-6 (N)



PERENNIAL MEDIUM

Baptisia australis

FALSE INDIGO A clump-forming perennial with gray-green divided foliage, it thrives in well-drained soils and will decorate a slope with its spikes of small violet-blue summer flowers. Decorative dark gray seedpods form in fall.

↑30in (75cm) ↔24in (60cm)

☹ ☀️ Z3-9 (N)



SHRUB LARGE

Berberis darwinii

DARWIN'S BARBERRY This tough and spiny evergreen shrub lends structure and height to a sloping site. Its tiny hollylike leaves are joined in spring by pendent clusters of dark orange flowers, which attract bees and are followed by blue-black berries.

↑↔10ft (3m)

☹ ☀️ ⚠️ Z7-9



SHRUB LARGE

Berberis x stenophylla

HEDGE BARBERRY Use this prickly evergreen shrub to decorate a bank or slope with its spine-tipped dark green leaves and small yellow spring flowers followed by blue-black fruits. Trim lightly in summer after the flowers have faded.

↑10ft (3m) ↔15ft (5m)

☹ ☀️ Z6-9



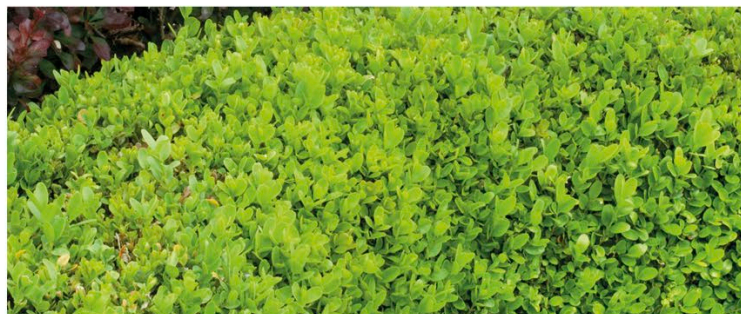
PERENNIAL SMALL

Bergenia purpurascens

PURPLE BERGENIA Tolerant of the free-draining conditions on a slope, this evergreen perennial forms clumps of large, fleshy rounded leaves that flush purple in cold weather, and clusters of dark pink spring blooms. Remove faded flower heads.

↑16in (40cm) ↔24in (60cm) or more

☹ ☀️ ☀️ Z3-8



SHRUB LARGE

Buxus sempervirens

COMMON BOXWOOD This traditional topiary and hedging evergreen shrub tolerates a wide range of conditions and grows well on a slope. Clip its small, oval glossy leaves to form hedges and green sculptures. Prune between early- to late summer.

↑↔15ft (5m)

☹ ☀️ Z6-8



SHRUB SMALL

Calluna vulgaris 'Gold Haze'

SCOTCH HEATHER A ground-hugging shrub, it has evolved to cope with life on moors and hillsides. Carpet a slope with its scaly foliage and small white flowers, which appear from late summer to fall. Needs acidic soil.

↑18in (45cm) ↔24in (60cm)

☹ ☀️ pH Z4-7